UPWORK / CLIENT DECISION FLOWCHART

Hire clearly. Review fairly.

For business owners, hiring managers and project leads • DRAFT • 28 October 2026

1 CLEAR BRIEF? [R+J]
Scope + budget agreed?

NO → **CLARIFY FIRST**
Define “done”, revisions, deadline and full budget. Then recheck gate 1.

BUDGET CHECK [J]
Include client fees, taxes where applicable and your review time. Use live fees [2].

YES

2 CONVINCING FIT? [R+J]
Skills + availability checked?

NO → **CHECK OR RESELECT**
Discuss relevant samples, who will do the work and a small paid pilot if useful. Then recheck gate 2.

FAIR SELECTION [J]
Do not rely only on stars or the lowest price. Do not ask for unpaid production work.

YES

3 READY TO START? [P+J]
Contract + payment set up?

NO → **RESOLVE BEFORE WORK**
Confirm scope, contract and payment setup. Then recheck gate 3.

CHOOSE THE ROUTE [3–4]
FIXED: fund the agreed milestone before work starts. HOURLY: agree rate, weekly limit and time-recording method; review work diary.

YES

AUTHORISE AGREED WORK

4 SCOPE CHANGED? [R+J]
New work, not a correction?

YES → **AGREE THE CHANGE**
Confirm extra cost, delivery and deadline in writing; fund milestone if needed. Then authorise revised work.

NO

5 REVIEW DELIVERY [P+J]
Use the agreed acceptance criteria and contract workflow.

WATCH THE CLOCK [3–4]
FIXED: 14-day review window; inaction can release funds. HOURLY: check bills weekly; dispute deadlines apply.

MATCHES AGREEMENT?
Check output, not just activity.

YES → **APPROVE / CONTINUE**
Pay for agreed work. Close out access when finished.

NO → **SPECIFY THE MISMATCH**
Request agreed corrections, not unpaid extras. Resolved? Review again.

REVIEW AGAIN

UNRESOLVED

6 UNRESOLVED? DOCUMENT + ESCALATE [P+J]
Preserve the brief, approvals, work and billing records.
Use the official dispute/refund route promptly [3–4].
Check your deadline; a support message is not a filed dispute.

SAFETY OVERRIDE AT ANY STAGE [P+J]
Decline fake reviews, identity misuse or fee-avoidance workarounds. Check conversion rules [5].
Limit access to business systems; secure compromised access.

HOW TO READ THE EVIDENCE

R = paper-reported; LOW confidence for generalising. P = stated platform rule, not proof of fair outcomes.

J = practical judgement, not tested by the paper. These are plain-language labels, not formal GRADE ratings.

LIMITS: The paper reports 218 studies/reports, 495 perspectives and 50 enforcement sources; overlap is unclear.
The PDF lacks a full auditable source inventory and extraction dataset. No validated hiring algorithm or risk estimate.
Supplied PDF: 15 July 2024; task metadata: 2026. Policy checks: 28 October 2026, search-indexed official text only;
direct pages blocked (403). Recheck live terms, exceptions and deadlines. No guarantee of quality or a refund.

[1] Leocadio, Navigating Upwork, pp. 2–4, 22–24, 34–36. https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6031034
[2] Upwork: Client Marketplace Fee. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/4660220468499
[3] Upwork: Fixed-price review. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/17974824831507
[4] Upwork: Hourly disputes. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/17976540792467
[5] Upwork: Off-platform payments. https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/360048105134

EXPERT SIGN-OFF: Author/methods + platform-policy adviser + client/freelancer usability review. Not legal advice; not Upwork-endorsed.